Framing A ‘Conflict’ Meeting

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Conflict Meeting Psychology

Dan Sperber – evolutionary psychologist.

The function of the internalised thought processes of reason and logic are to help us to argue; to **manipulate and convince** others to meet our own survival needs and to be **wary** when others attempt to do the same to us.

As an example: Small (physical) man back in 'caveman times' - has to try and 'negotiate' with stronger men in order to gain a share of the food. Learns to manipulate others without physical force.

Confirmation bias is 'proof' as it serves to identify more information to support your own argument. If the purpose of self reasoning was to help build better beliefs and make better decisions, it wouldn't come with a bias!

Remember, a Double Blind (Placebo) Study is a Scientific Method to Avoid Confirmation Bias for the Researcher; such is the corruptive influence of our own internal dialogue…

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Conflict Meeting Psychology continued...

The Psychological approach deals with the phenomenon known as 'detachment'.

Background: In essence, we seek to understand something by reference to associations to same or similar experiences or information. This associative learning allows us to rapidly interpret and react to stimuli and supports the cognitive functions during fight or flight response.

Therefore, it stands to reason that once we've made an association to something, we believe we know 'what it is' and 'what it means'. Via our process of association, we effectively 'take ownership' of our understanding. *(Which is why you often see people 'doubling down' on their stated beliefs - even in the face of obvious new {conflicting} information.)*

Recognising this requires that we create a 'cognitive pathway' for our clients to 'let go' of the emotional attachment to their understanding since in order to accept new information, we must *(first)* be prepared to let go of current beliefs or understanding without feeling a 'loss of self'.

A therapeutic session would encourage a client to reflect on 'what it means to discover you held incorrect beliefs or information'. A *(disturb)* question such as "do you remember who the first person was, to tell you santa claus wasn't real?" - supported by an *(affirming)* question "did believing in santa claus make you less of a person?" - finished with an *(aspirational)* question "is it possible, that the process of learning that a once firmly held belief was incorrect, releasing it, and accepting a new understanding, actually gave you the early life experience that you can change a belief and NOT be any weaker for it?"

Prescribed Cognitive Pathway: "We can conclude from this that in fact, holding on to a belief or understanding from fear of learning we were wrong is actually detrimental to our well being and potentially dangerous. Our desire to avoid feelings of *(short term)* embarrassment or shame is only because we took 'ownership' of our understanding. If we seek to experience life on the basis of 'information to date' - equals new information, means new understanding - then we'll be better able to adapt to our changing world and therefore be safer and potentially, happier."

Going Forward - we must seek understanding with an open heart and an open mind. *(ask them to describe what this statement means to them)*

Conflict Meeting Psychology continued…

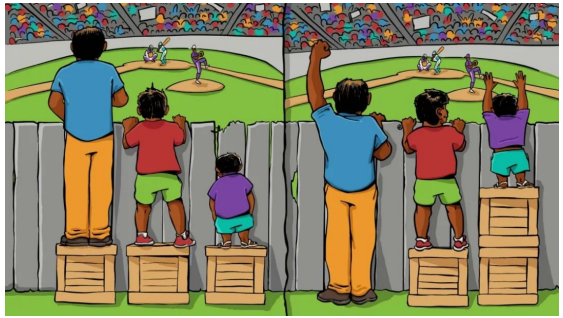
The **Objective** is to create an environment where people can 'catch themselves' acting in violation of higher values, and decide to 'let go' of their current position for the greater good.

The **Process** is as follows…

1. Show them the 'light'. *"We're here to define a process that allows everyone to walk away with a solution they can live with. Not everything they demand, not rewarded for starting high so they can falsely lay claim to concessions; but realistic solutions to fair and honest requests that everyone can live with."*
2. Find early alignment. Quickly identify the people that 'want the same outcome' but disagree on the process/ methodology.
3. Separate the outcome from the process. By shifting the focus to the process, we reduce 'energy' on the problem.
4. Show them the 'Cliff Face' and Highlight the 'Grab Rails'. Allow those that are in defence of their position to see the extreme consequence *(of scorched earth tactics)* and agree to 'let-go' and 'live with' a central outcome; unless it's illegal, unethical or immoral.
5. Praise *(even small)* acts of progress. Thank *(publicly)* those who relent or contribute to a positive meeting environment.
6. Use time (and the ability for people to reflect in private) to your advantage. *"We're going to take a quick coffee break now and I want each of you to find at least 1 thing you can suggest to make progress here today, that does not come at the cost of others." - "I think we've achieved as much as we could expect for the day; I recommend we agree on a future meeting date (here and now) and continue the agreed process when we meet again."*

As A Facilitator

You are attempting to sustain…

The Person	The Method	The Outcome
Separate the emotional attachment from the 'belief' - only then can you position a new belief (if required)	This serves as the focus, the mental alignment to achieve collaboration. The method should inspire confidence and affirm beliefs gained from the experience.	Need be Equitable, not necessarily Equal. *(Best explained by picture below)*
The 'person' must be able to accept a new position without the feeling of loss of 'self'. Loss of self is more than just 'loss of face' - it includes the acceptance of conflicting values. (Which requires emotional maturity to accept conflicting beliefs may work in harmony - ex "I love my job but I can't work there anymore.")	In order for the method to serve as 'mental guidance' it must be easy to learn and recall since it's often in (separate) reflection periods that 'buyers remorse' sets in and clients backtrack on their agreements. It's at these times that the process should be easy to remember.	

3 Concepts To Support Your Framing

1. **Achieve Status & Share it Quickly**
2. **Call Out The Ghosts!**

   (Expose poor behaviour in advance or Pre-Empt bad news and underlying fears)

3. **Establish Context**

   (Worst Case - Current Case - Best Case)

Achieving Status

Achieving a strong status position is just 'part of the dance'…

The reason we need a strong Status Position is so we can ensure significant

Arousal

The physiological and psychological state of the Sense Organs being stimulated to a point of PERCEPTION.

Perception: The combination of received stimuli (sensations) with past memories, and the interpretation of the bodies physical response.

Instinctual Drives: Self Preservation – Sexual – Self Pleasure
Avoid Pain – Gain Pleasure

In everyday life this translates to…
Should I chase it or run from it?

In Sales, this translates to…
Should I tune in, or tune out?

Achieving Status - Key Points to Remember

Status comes in two levels - Global and Local

An easy way to remember this is - Who has greater status, a heart surgeon or the local pub 'pool shark'? *(Pool table/ Billiards etc)*

The answer is… it depends on the context. If the discussion is about personal earnings or impact on society - perhaps the surgeon, but if both are playing a game of pool and the surgeon has failed to sink a single ball…

The thing about achieving Status (Hierarchical Dominance) is that it's important to 'Share' the status position as soon as possible. One technique is to assign a task to a vocal adversary. "Hey Bob, I know you're concerned about this meeting running over time; can I ask you to watch the clock and remind everyone when there's 10 mins remaining so we can cover Q&A and end 5 mins early. If I go over time, you're in charge of the team to throw me out the window!"

DELIVERY is critical to achieving status; the 4 points to practise in your delivery is:

PHYSIOLOGY & PACE -Congruent gestures and pace. (Sometimes referred to as Mirroring)
INTENT - Your genuine intentions for positive meeting outcomes for all in attendance.
FRAMEWORKS - The problem solving (Conceptual Hierarchies) that display clear evidence of thought logic and prior consideration.
TONALITY - Delivering your message *at the correct pitch.*